

Core Web Vitals Optimization Guide

LCP, INP & CLS Playbook

Core Web Vitals are a confirmed ranking factor and a direct conversion lever. This guide walks the three metrics that matter, the failures that cause them, and the fix for each — ordered by impact so you start where the gains are biggest.

What's inside

- LCP diagnosis: which element is actually largest
- INP fixes for heavy JavaScript main threads
- CLS elimination via dimension reservation
- Image and font loading priority rules
- Field vs lab data — which to trust when

Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)

- 01 Identify the true LCP element in DevTools before optimising anything
- 02 Preload the hero image and set `fetchpriority="high"`
- 03 Serve responsive sizes so mobile never downloads desktop assets
- 04 Eliminate render-blocking CSS above the fold

Interaction to Next Paint (INP)

- 01 Break long tasks over 50ms into smaller chunks
- 02 Defer non-critical third-party scripts to after interaction
- 03 Debounce expensive input handlers and scroll listeners
- 04 Audit chat widgets and pixels — they are the usual culprits

Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)

- 01 Set explicit width and height on every image and embed
- 02 Reserve space for ads, banners, and cookie notices
- 03 Use font-display: swap with a matched fallback metric
- 04 Never insert content above existing content after load

Measurement Discipline

- 01 Use CrUX field data for truth, Lighthouse for diagnosis
- 02 Test on throttled 4G and mid-tier mobile, not your laptop
- 03 Re-measure after every deploy, not once per quarter
- 04 Track the 75th percentile — averages hide real pain

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